

Chapter

Rigid Mind, Flexible Intellect — The Art of Rewriting Destiny



Introduction: "We Are Just Like This"

How often do we say, "That's just my nature," or "That's how things are in our family"? In this short discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji shows that this very sentence is the root of the obstacles in our lives. He explains the difference between **medha** (an intellect refined and made radiant by the scriptures) and **durmedha** (a stubborn, inert intellect), and shows that whoever wishes to rise in life needs a **flexible** intellect, not a **rigid** one.

1. Medha Knows: Destiny Can Be Rewritten

According to Acharya Ji, a person of **medha** is one into whom the scriptures have truly settled:

"The person of medha thinks, because all the scriptures are seated within him. All the scriptures have been followed; the radiance has come."

And so he knows a fundamental truth about destiny:

"He knows — destiny changeable. Destiny can be rewritten, he knows that. Destiny pre-written, but also can be rewritten — the person of medha knows this."

Destiny is written in advance, but it can also be rewritten. That is the mark of **medha**.

2. Durmedha: "No One Has Ever Changed"

Its exact opposite is **durmedha** — the intellect that refuses to change:

"So what will the person of durmedha say? 'We are just like this. In our home it is just like this. Till today, nobody has changed. Show me another ideal, then perhaps I will change...'"

Acharya Ji states the consequence plainly:

"These people of durmedha are very, very far from Parameshwar, from the Guru. Ganapati is not even near them. Ganapati means the discerning intellect, the steady intellect — that is nowhere to be found in them."

Ganapati is the remover of obstacles; where there is no discerning intellect, there are only obstacles:

"And your obstacles are coming for this very reason — because you are rigid. Because everywhere else things will be flexible; everyone else will be different, of course."

The world will keep changing and people will always be different; the one who digs in their heels is the one who collides.

3. One Room, Two Points of View

Acharya Ji explains this with a simple scene. Two people are in the same room, looking from different places:

"This man sitting on the chair says: 'Look, there's a wall; look, a door; look, a cupboard; yes, look, there are clothes behind...' The other says: 'No, look, there's a window; look, you can see a tree outside; look, there's that curtain...'"

Then the question: who is right?

"Who is right and who is wrong? Each one's point of view is right. Because what this one sees is right, and what that one sees is also right."

The problem is not the viewpoint, but clinging to it:

"Both held on to their own viewpoint like this, stayed rigid — saying 'my nature cannot change,' then 'I will accept only mine, I will do only mine.' Now what will happen? Will they fight or not? They will never match in this world."

And the solution:

"Won't each have to change his nature and, for some time, become like this (stand in the other's place)? When that happens, he will see that this one was also right, and that one was also right."

Without standing in the other's place, you cannot see their truth.

4. "Have You Lived Their Life?"

Acharya Ji brings the same point into daily life — to the hardships of a domestic helper or a poor person:

"When your maid says, 'Sahab, my husband comes home drunk, creates trouble, kicks me...' — and you stay in your attitude: 'How can that be? You can't come? We also go to the office.'"

His question is direct:

"Have you lived her life? Does your husband kick you? How much insult and abuse that is! Do they have as much money as you?"

"When will you look at her life? That is why her intellect runs from her angle, and your intellect runs from your angle."

Every person thinks from the **angle** of their own circumstances. It is easy to dismiss it as "their nature"; seeing their circumstances is what a flexible intellect does.

5. One Goal, Many Natures

Now Acharya Ji gives the central principle of this teaching — for the one who wishes to rise, who wishes to **uphold** others:

"Whoever wants to be higher, whoever wants to be a dharta, a sustainer who upholds others, whoever wants to become a king, an emperor, or any higher post like a manager — he will have to be this flexible. He will have to change his nature for everything."

"One can run with one goal; one cannot run with one nature."

Let the goal be unshakable and the nature flexible. That is the secret of leadership.

6. See God in All, but Treat on Merit

Flexible in which direction? Acharya Ji makes it clear that the purpose remains one — Parameshwar:

"Parameshwar's purpose can run through it. In it I will see God everywhere, I will see Him even in a dog, but I will treat the dog the way a dog is to be treated. Treat on merit. See God in all, but treat on merit."

"The vision of Bhagavan in all, but not the same conduct."

That is: see God in everyone, but do not behave (**vartan**) the same way with everyone. He illustrates it with the example of feeding everyone:

"In the poor too there is God — Shanidev. But his treatment is different. The treatment will not be bad, it will only be good, but its manner is different. Volunteers will have to be put in place, because Mangal controls Shani — Mangal means police, volunteers, all that. Then those people of lower consciousness will eat their food properly."

"If someone of a higher post, a saint or sadhu, is brought, there is no need to tell him to stand in line. The respect is different. He gets good food too, this one gets good food too, the dog gets good food too. God in each one, but each with his own treatment."

That everyone receives something **good** is the same; **how** they receive it changes with the person.

"Will I have to change this nature of mine or not? Just this much understanding should come to me."

7. Be Ganapati, Not a Flatterer

Finally, Acharya Ji drives the point home with a witty comparison:

"Am I a dog, that I should treat everyone the same way — lick this one, lick that one too? There isn't just one way to love."

"Perhaps that's why they say **chatukar** (flatterer; literally, 'one who licks') — he does everything one single way; he only knows one way. But you should have the intelligence to act differently — whatever is needed, wherever it is needed."

And here the meaning of Ganapati returns — **Ganapati**, the lord (**adhipati**) of the **ganas**, the groups of people:

"However much you want to become Ganapati, however much you want to become the lord of the ganas, however high a post you want to hold — that much you will have to make your intellect flexible."

Summary: Key Takeaways

- 1** **Destiny can be changed** — "Destiny pre-written, but also can be rewritten"; the intellect of **medha** knows this.
- 2** **"We are just like this" is the sign of durmedha** — such an intellect stays far from Parameshwar, the Guru and Ganapati (the discerning intellect).
- 3** **Obstacles come from rigidity** — the world and people will always be different; the one who is rigid is the one who collides.
- 4** **Every viewpoint is right from where it stands** — only by standing in the other's place do you see their truth.
- 5** **Look at the other's life** — each person's intellect runs from the angle of their circumstances.

- 6 **One goal, many natures** — whoever wants to rise and uphold others must be flexible.
- 7 **See God in all, but treat on merit** — the vision of God in everyone, but conduct suited to each; good for all, but each in their own way.
- 8 **There isn't just one way to love** — treating everyone the same way is flattery; the intelligence to act differently is the quality of Ganapati, the lord of the *ganas*.